

A FAITHFUL PATH COMMUNITY GUIDE

The Christian Spiritual Reset

*A 3-Day Guided Retreat to Overcome Burnout,
Hear God Clearly, and Renew Your Faith*

Pastor Richmond Kobe

FAITHFUL PATH COMMUNITY

Copyright

The Christian Spiritual Reset: A 3-Day Guided Retreat to Overcome Burnout, Hear God Clearly, and Renew Your Faith Copyright © 2026 Richmond Kobe. All rights reserved.

Published by Faithful Path Community,
faithfulpathcommunity.com. First edition, 2026.

No part of this publication may be reproduced, stored, or transmitted in any form without the prior written permission of the author, except for brief quotations in reviews and for the personal, non- commercial use of the purchaser, including printing the session pages for use on retreat.

Scripture quotations are from the ESV® Bible (The Holy Bible, English Standard Version®), © 2001 by Crossway, a publishing ministry of Good News Publishers. ESV Text Edition: 2025. The ESV text may not be quoted in any publication made available to the public by a Creative Commons license. The ESV may not be translated in whole or in part into any other language. Used by permission. All rights reserved. Where another translation is used, it is identified.

This book offers pastoral guidance. It is not medical, psychological, psychiatric, or legal advice, and it is not a substitute for professional care. See the note below and the Resources page at the back.

Contact: info@faithfulpathcommunity.com

CHAPTER 13

Testing What You Believe You Heard

For the first morning home

You are back. The house is loud, or the inbox is, or the children are, and the quiet of the retreat already feels like something that happened to someone else. That is normal, and Session Ten warned you about it.

Do not make any decisions today. This morning, read the chapter, sort your cards into the three categories below, and identify what will need testing. The full testing may take days or weeks. Your whole assignment for the first morning is this:

1. Sort each card into one of the three categories.
2. Take no major action today.
3. Do any immediately necessary safety action; see the exception below.
4. Schedule a conversation with the appropriate adviser.
5. Put a date on the worksheet for beginning and reviewing the test. Then let the rest of the day be ordinary.

This chapter is about one card in particular: the one from Session Seven marked *What I sense*, and any cards marked *To test* from

Session Nine. Session Seven asked you to write down what you sensed and to test it before acting. This is how.

Why testing is faith, not doubt

Some readers will feel that testing an impression from a retreat is a failure of trust. If God spoke, why examine it? The answer is that Scripture commands examination precisely because God speaks and because we are fallible receivers. **1 Thessalonians 5:20–21** says, "Do not despise prophecies, but test everything; hold fast what is good." Paul holds both together: do not dismiss what may be from God, and do not accept it untested. The Bereans in **Acts 17:11** were called "more noble" because they received Paul's teaching eagerly *and* examined the Scriptures daily to see whether it was so. Neither passage is specifically about private impressions on retreat, but together they establish a clear Christian posture: receive spiritual claims openly and examine them carefully.

Testing does not insult God. It honours him by refusing to attach his name to something that may be our own fear, desire, or exhaustion. Session Seven said that any of us can mistake strong emotion for divine direction, especially when tired. You were tired. Test it.

The safety exception

Everything in this chapter about waiting, consulting, and taking time applies to ordinary discernment. It does not apply to immediate danger, abuse, urgent medical care, legal reporting duties, or deadlines that cannot safely be postponed. In those situations, seek qualified help and take the safest necessary action now. Do not remain in danger merely to complete a discernment process. Chapter 5's guidance on abuse and crisis takes precedence over anything below.

First, sort what you have

Take out the *What I sense* card and any *To test* cards, and sort them into three kinds.

Nothing significant. If the card says "nothing," or records only a general sense of peace, or a familiar verse without any particular direction attached, there is nothing to test. Put it in the journal as a record of the retreat and move on to Chapter 14. Many readers will be here, and Chapter 12 already said that this is a complete outcome.

A low-risk, reversible step. Contacting a counsellor to arrange an initial appointment. Asking a trusted person for a conversation. Protecting one two-hour period for rest this week. Gathering information about reducing your hours. Writing an apology without sending it yet. These are the kind of actions Session Seven already permitted: supported by Scripture and ordinary wisdom, easily undone if mistaken, and harmful to no one. Notice that each of these explores a step rather than executes it; that distinction is worth keeping throughout. Test them lightly, using the worksheet quickly, and then do them.

A major, high-impact, costly, or difficult-to-reverse direction. Leaving a job, a church, a marriage, or a country. Starting a ministry. Making a large financial commitment. Confronting someone or disclosing something that will change relationships. Changing the course of your family's life. Anything that affects other people substantially or cannot easily be undone. These get the full testing below, over weeks, with other people, and they do not get acted on until the testing is done, subject always to the safety exception above.

Most of what people bring home from retreats is in the second category. If yours is in the third, be glad that you wrote it down instead of acting on it, and give it the time it needs.

The tests, applied

Session Seven listed nine tests. Here is how to actually use them. Work through them in your journal, one at a time, and give each a status: *supports*, *raises concern*, *not yet examined*, or *requires qualified advice*.

1. Does it agree with Scripture, read in context? This is the first and weightiest test, and it is not passed by finding a verse that matches. Ask what the whole of Scripture teaches about the kind of thing you are considering: about vows and commitments, about leaving and staying, about money, about family, about the church, about truth-telling. Read substantial passages, not fragments. If you are not sure what Scripture teaches, that is the first thing to find out, with help. An impression that contradicts clear biblical teaching fails here, and nothing else needs to be checked.

2. Does it reflect the character and fruit of Christ? Would acting on this reflect the Jesus of the Gospels: truthful, humble, compassionate, courageous, just, and appropriately self-giving? **Galatians 5:22–23** lists the fruit of the Spirit; hold the direction against that list. Christlike love is not self-erasure, submission to abuse, or refusal to maintain necessary boundaries. Directions that require you to become harder, more secretive, more self-important, or less accountable raise concern here regardless of how spiritual they sound.

3. Is it truthful about facts, not merely feelings? Write down the facts the direction depends on. If it is "leave this church because they do not value me," the facts are what has actually been said and done, not how it felt. If it is "start this ministry because there is a great need," the facts are whether the need exists, whether others are already meeting it, and whether you have the capacity.

Then check the facts, with people who know. Impressions often rest on interpretations that turn out to be partly true.

4. Does it withstand time and careful questioning? Give it time. For a category-three direction, a month at minimum, and often longer, subject to the safety exception. Notice whether the sense of it strengthens, weakens, or changes as the retreat recedes and ordinary life resumes. Question it yourself: what would I say to a friend who brought me this? What are the three strongest reasons not to do it? If you cannot think of any, you are not yet questioning it carefully.

5. What do mature and appropriately qualified advisers say? This is where your Eli comes in, and this test cannot be done alone. See below for how to consult well. For matters involving health, law, money, employment, or abuse, "qualified" means professionally qualified, not simply spiritually mature.

6. Does it respect safety, consent, justice, and accountability? Who is affected by this? Have they been considered? Does it require anyone to be harmed, deceived, pressured, or kept in the dark? Does it leave you accountable to someone, or does it place you beyond correction? When a decision rightly belongs to more than one person, those affected should ordinarily have a voice before it is made. This does not mean that an unsafe, abusive, or controlling person receives a veto over your safety, or that someone must be warned before a confidential safeguarding or legal report is made.

7. Does it require secrecy, superiority, recklessness, or immunity from challenge? Be honest. If you find yourself thinking "they would not understand," "God has shown me and that is enough," or "this is between me and God," those are warning signs, not confirmations. Urgency that exists mainly to prevent examination is also a warning sign; genuine safety

concerns, medical needs, reporting duties, and fixed external deadlines require prompt action with appropriate advice, but "I have to act before anyone can talk me out of it" is not one of those. Genuine direction from God can bear examination. It does not need protecting from wise people.

8. Is the proposed action proportionate and reversible? If there is a smaller, reversible version of the same step, take that first. Reduce hours before resigning. Have the conversation before leaving. Trial the ministry before founding it. Test the direction with a step you can undo, and let the result inform the larger question.

9. Are you sufficiently rested, regulated, informed, and supported to make this decision? Strong emotion does not automatically invalidate a decision. It may mean that you need more time, additional support, or professional guidance before making a high-impact choice. If you are still in the post-retreat dip, or exhausted, or in the middle of a crisis, a category-three decision can usually wait until you are in better condition to make it. Urgent safety decisions cannot wait, and should not be postponed simply because you are distressed; get help to make them.

How to consult your Eli

Session Seven asked you to name a mature, trustworthy Christian who knows Scripture, understands your situation, respects boundaries, and has no interest in controlling your decision. Contact them this week and ask for an hour. Then:

Bring the card, your journal answers to the nine tests, and the facts from test three. Tell them what you sensed, how, and when. Tell them you are not asking them to confirm it; you are asking them to help you test it.

Ask three questions. What in this do you recognise as wise? What concerns you? What have I not considered? Then listen without defending. Their concerns are the most valuable thing they will give you.

Your Eli does not have to supply every kind of wisdom. A pastor may help you test the spiritual reasoning while a doctor, lawyer, counsellor, financial adviser, or safeguarding professional addresses the facts within their competence. For a major decision, you may need a spiritually mature adviser, a qualified professional, the people affected where consultation is safe, and, where governance is involved, the relevant church or organisational authority.

Do not choose an Eli who will simply agree with you, and do not go from adviser to adviser until you find one who does. If two wise people independently raise the same concern, weigh it heavily. If your spouse, where you have one, has serious reservations about a direction that affects the family, that is not an obstacle to overcome; it is part of the test. This assumes a relationship in which concerns can be expressed without coercion or fear. In an abusive relationship, consult a domestic-abuse specialist privately; joint discernment may not be safe.

When the tests disagree

Sometimes the tests point in different directions. Scripture permits it, the fruit seems good, but your Eli has concerns; or the facts check out, but you are not yet rested enough to decide. When that happens, the direction is not ready, and that is the answer for now. Not "no," but "not yet." Keep testing. Revisit in a month. Many directions that are genuinely from God arrive slowly and survive a long wait; directions that need to be acted on immediately, before anyone can weigh in, rarely are.

If a direction fails a test clearly, particularly test one, let it go. Session Seven said this: if an impression conflicts with Scripture, promotes harm, or cannot withstand truthful examination, do not treat it as divine direction. That is not a loss. It is the testing doing what it was for.

And if, after weeks of testing, a category-three direction has passed every test, has been weighed by wise people who know you, and still holds, then it may be time to act, with the proportionate step first. Passing the tests does not give infallible certainty or guarantee a particular outcome. It means the direction has become responsible enough to take a proportionate next step. Chapter 14 is about that.

A note on fleeces and signs

Some readers will be tempted to ask God for a sign to settle the matter: a fleece, after Gideon in **Judges 6:36–40**. Be cautious. Gideon's fleece is recorded, not commended; he already had God's clear word and was asking for reassurance, and the narrative presents him as hesitant rather than exemplary. Signs are easy to manufacture and easy to misread. If you want confirmation, seek it through the ordinary means Scripture commends: Scripture itself, truthful examination, wise counsel, time, prayer, and the fruit produced, rather than trying to decode coincidences.

A worksheet

Copy this into your journal for each card you are testing. For each test, record a status: supports / raises concern / not yet examined / requires qualified advice.

*What I sensed: Category: nothing significant / low-risk
and reversible / major or high-impact Safety exception*

applies? yes / no 1.

Scripture, in context: Status: 2.

Character and fruit of Christ: Status: 3.

Facts it depends on, and whether checked: Status: 4.

Time given so far, and what has changed: Status: 5.

Advisers consulted, and what each said: Status: 6.

Safety, consent, justice, accountability: Status: 7.

*Secrecy, superiority, urgency, immunity from
challenge: Status: 8.*

Proportionate, reversible first step: Status: 9.

*My present condition to decide: Status: Testing begins:
_____ Review on: _____ Verdict for now: act on
the small step / not yet, revisit on _____ / let it go*

Before Chapter 14

1. Which category does your card fall into? If nothing significant, go to Chapter 14 with a clear conscience.
2. Does the safety exception apply to anything? If so, what help are you seeking today?
3. When will you contact your Eli, and what will you bring?
4. What is the smallest reversible version of any step you are considering?
5. Is there anything you are reluctant to test? Write down why. Reluctance to test is itself something to test.